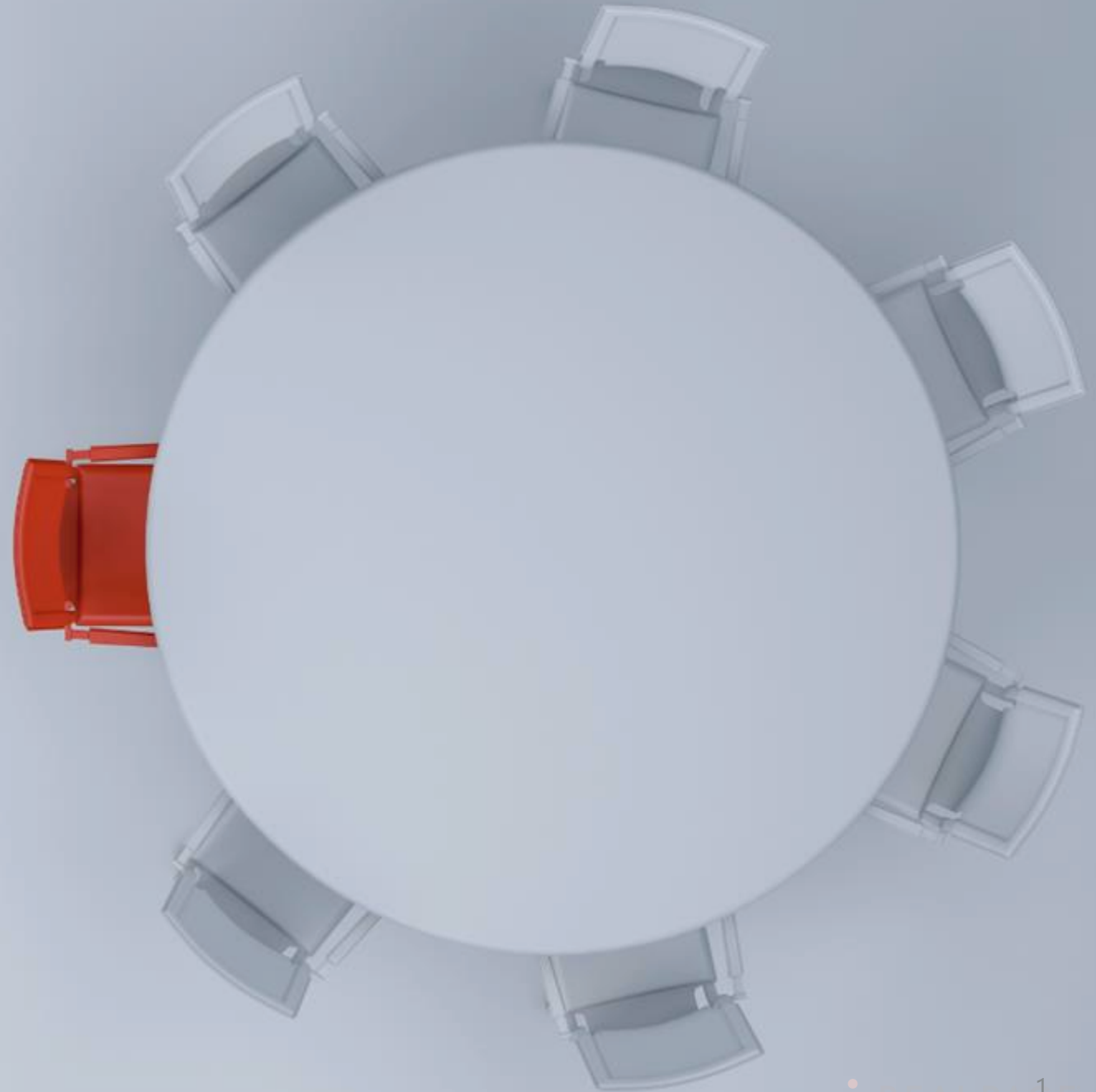


Team Discussion Framework

Leader's Guide to Open Dialogue and Feedback

If you would like a member of the HR team to co-facilitate a session with you, please let us know.

Please reach out to your HRBP.



PURPOSE

As the business landscape continuously transforms, leaders must understand the **challenges** faced within their team and across the organization.

By fostering open dialogue leaders can ensure teams are aligned and can **navigate** these changes effectively.

This guide aims to provide steps to help your team **reflect**, **revitalize**, and **renew** their commitment to their role, the team and RealPage.



CHANGE IS THE ONLY CONSTANT

Leadership is the key to change success! Our actions determine if employees feel that change is happening to them or if they are a part of the change effort.

Many Organizations are **overwhelmed** by change and/or are experience change fatigue.

The average organization has been through **5 changes** in the past **three** years.

More than **75%** of organizations expect **more changes** across the next **three** years.

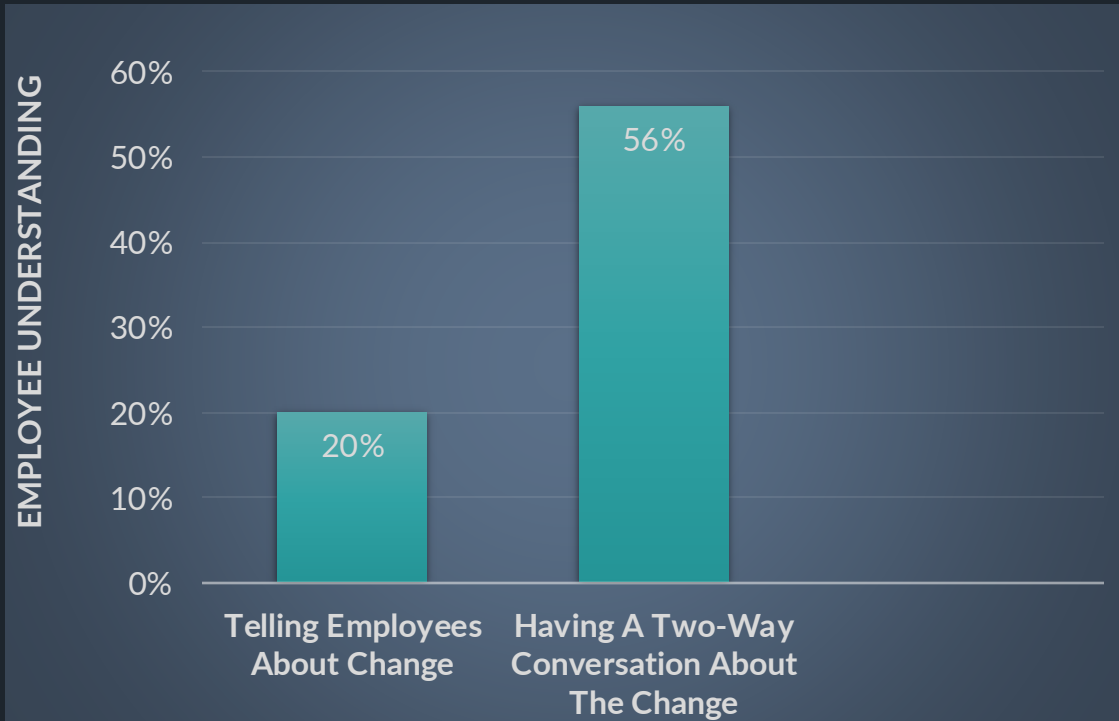
Managers play a critical role in helping **change** succeed.

Managers **connect** employees with the larger organization:

- They **communicate** change messages to employees.
- They help employees **implement** the required changes.
- They **engage** employees in feeling part of the change objectives and decisions.

TWO-WAY COMMUNICATION IS THE KEY

Only **TELLING** employees about change reduces understanding and increases anxiety or anger.



Source: Gartner/CEB Workforce Change Survey



Employees are **5x** more likely to feel angry about a change when they are not involved in **two-way** conversations.

Respondents were asked whether they understood how the change affected their team's work, their responsibilities, their role in the change, and who they needed to work with in order to be successful. Those who understood two or more of these aspects "understood the change."

STEPS TO BUILD SUCCESSFUL TWO-WAY CONVERSATIONS

MANAGERS MUST UNDERSTAND HOW CHANGE WILL AFFECT THEIR TEAM, HAVE **HONEST** CONVERSATIONS TO ENABLE EMPLOYEE **OWNERSHIP**, SUPPORT AND DISCUSS HOW EMPLOYEES PLAN TO **IMPLEMENT** CHANGE.

01 Prepare the conversation • Process your own emotions • Understand the impacts for your team • Set the meeting with agenda • Identify participants/moderator	02 Open the Conversation • Welcome and Introduction • Recording is not recommended • Set Ground Rules • Introduce Moderator • Acknowledge the Change	03 During the Conversation • Promote Inclusivity - involve the participants • Be a good and active listener • Express empathy and address feelings • Identify Challenges • Offer Support and Collaboration • Discuss Solutions
04 Focus on the Future State • Collaborate on Goal Setting • Seek advice for implementing the changes • Conduct Ongoing Conversations	05 Wrap-up/Closing • Summarize themes and next steps • Express Appreciation • Follow-up with your team • Conduct Anonymous Survey	06 Tips to Stay on Track • Reaffirm the Agenda/Key Topics • Use a Parking Lot • Implement Time Management • Keep Additional Topics Handy • Ask Open-Ended Questions



*See Appendix For More Information

1. PREPARE THE CONVERSATION

Set the Agenda

- **Define Objectives**
 - Clearly outline the goals of the meeting
- **Prepare Key Points:**
 - Focus on the change and its impact

Choose a Comfortable Setting (in-person/remote)

- **Neutral Environment:**
 - Select a location that is comfortable and neutral
- **Inclusive Communication:**
 - Ensure the setting promotes open dialogue
 - In-person - seat participants in a circle to assure a sense of equal participation
 - Remote - request for cameras to be on but don't request repeatedly or make mandatory

Invite Participants

- **Inform the Team:**
 - Clearly Communicate the meeting's purpose
 - Schedule a 60-90 mins meeting
 - 8-12 participants per group (if possible)
- **Encourage Preparation:**
 - Allow team members time to gather their thought and questions



1. PREPARE THE CONVERSATION (CONT'D)

USE THESE QUESTIONS TO ENSURE YOU UNDERSTAND **YOUR OWN EMOTIONAL REACTION** TO THE CHANGE AND HOW THE CHANGE WILL AFFECT THE WAY YOUR DIRECT REPORTS GET THEIR WORK DONE.

Process your own emotional reaction to how you will be affected.

- What was my initial reaction to the change? Did I feel anxious, frustrated, or excited?
- What was most the productive thing I did to work through these emotions?
- What can I learn from my reaction that might apply to how I communicate with my direct reports or how I approach the conversation? What tips would I give them?
- What should I do differently compared to how the change was communicated to me or how I have communicated changes in the past?
- Are there any peers or leaders whose approach to communicating change I admire? How can I imitate them?

Ensure you understand the implications of the change for your team.

- Why does the organization have to change and what will success look like?
- How does this affect my direct reports and their needs and tasks?
- Does it affect all of them in the same way?
- When will they be affected, and when do they need to make the changes?
- How do my direct reports' behaviors and decisions have to change because of this change? How dramatic will this change feel to them?
- What do I think are the obstacles and risks of implementing this change? What might they think?
- Is this change news to them, or are they likely to have heard about it already?
- Is there a perception of fatigue related to this or other changes? How relevant and how urgent is this information for them?
- Are there other priorities that I need my direct reports to focus on? How should they balance these with the new demands placed on them?
- Do I have enough information to help my direct reports think creatively about how to support the change? Can I address areas of uncertainty that lack sufficient information?



2. OPEN THE CONVERSATION

Opening is done by the designated senior leader and should include the following:

- A warm welcome and an expression of appreciation for their participation
- Clear explanation as to why the session is being held and how it is being viewed by the organization (e.g., the description of what led to the session and that this is one of an ongoing series of conversations).
- An explanation of the aim for the session , which should include:
 - Provide a forum for employees to be heard
 - Create a shared understanding of the issues and the impact
 - Further opportunities for employees to be a part of the solution
 - Make sure that everyone knows that they are not only not alone and have support
 - Share description on how the input from this session will be used (i.e., themes and concepts only—no individual attribution)
 - Introduce the moderator/note-taker
- Recording the session is highly discouraged

Ground rules are a list of terms that participants agree to follow, and the facilitator agrees to uphold during the session.

- Commit to making this a safe space for honest expression
- Share responsibility for including all voices in the conversation
- Refrain from attributing any comments to a specific individual(s) after the session is over
- Be honest but constructive—no “bashing” others
- Be concise to allow others to fully participate
- Limit distractions and avoid multitasking during the session



3. DURING THE CONVERSATION

Get employees involved in the conversation.

- Ask them to speak up: indicate that you have information to share but want to spend most of the time getting their reactions and/or ideas.
- Lead with their interests: Focus early discussions on issues that directly impact the employees.
- Ask open-ended questions: For example, "What could we be doing better?" or "What are we doing that works well?"
- Make it safe: Show genuine interest in different perspectives; avoid a critical or dismissive posture.
- Forge connections: Point out links or contrasts between employee opinions; aim to cultivate a "network effect" rather than a series of direct exchanges with you.

Be a good listener

- Listen, then gather more facts and details: For example, "Tell me more about that," or "Keep going, I'm following you."
- Listen, then validate their challenges: For example, "It sounds like our current plan could make it hard for the team to stay ahead of deadlines."
- Listen, then clarify meanings: For example, "I hear you saying you are frustrated with the lack of transparency—is that right?"
- Listen, then encourage elaboration: For example, "Why do you think this problem is so hard to eliminate?"
- Listen, then invite discovery: For example, "What could we do to make things better?"

Express Empathy and Address Feelings

- Empathize: "I understand that this change might be difficult for many of you."
- Normalize Feelings: "It's normal to feel uncertain or anxious during times like these."
- Invite Sharing of Feelings: "How are you feeling about the recent changes?"
- Affirm Emotions: "Your feelings are completely valid and understandable."



3. DURING THE CONVERSATION

Discuss Challenges

- Identify Challenges: "What challenges are you currently facing due to this change?"
- Identify Challenges: "What resources or support do you need to feel more comfortable with the changes?"
- Identify Challenges: "What specific tools or training would help you adapt to the new environment?"

Offer Support

- Reassure Team: "We are all in this together, and we will get through this by supporting one another."
- Reassure Team: "We are a resilient team, and with everyone's effort, we can make a successful transition forward."
- Offer Support: "We value your contributions and are here to provide resources and support you need."
- Offer Support: "Let's work together to find solutions and make this transition as smooth as possible."
- What can I learn from managers in other parts of the organization as to how their teams are implementing the change?
- How can my team help other teams in making the change?

Foster Open Communication and Collaboration

- Encourage Open Dialogue: "Please feel free to share any thoughts or ideas you have."
- Encourage Open Dialogue: "How can we improve our communication during this transition?"
- Promote Inclusivity: "Everyone's input is valuable, and we want to hear from all of you."
- Promote Inclusivity: "What can we do to ensure everyone feels included and valued during this time?"



3. DURING THE CONVERSATION

Admit uncertainty and the potential implications, where appropriate.

- Am I acknowledging in clear language a reduction in the workforce, team transfers, impact on benefits, or job security?
- Am I acknowledging the personal stress of adjusting to new conditions? Am I acknowledging if my direct reports will need to build new capabilities?
- Do I articulate the outcome I expect from this change, and do I admit where I don't have the answers? Do I articulate what my direct reports should and shouldn't do and where they are free to experiment?
- Do I admit when I don't have answers to their questions, and do I know where to find them or can I help my direct reports find them?

Ask questions that stimulate employees to think strategically about how they will be affected and can contribute to the change.

- Why is this change important to the organization? Why is it important to our team?
- How does this change align with your own personal goals? How about with the goals of your teammates? How do you plan to contribute to making the change a success?
- What do you need to know to understand the goal? Who might have the answers? How can we measure if our goals were achieved in the short term? In the long term? What will be hard about executing this change?
- Which of our processes might need to be updated? Which other changes could result from this change? What needs to be adjusted in your work or the work of your peers and managers?
- Has the team or someone else experienced a similar change in the past that we can learn from? Who do you need to work with that you don't already?



4. FOCUS ON THE FUTURE

USE THE QUESTIONS BELOW TO CHECK IN REGULARLY WITH YOUR DIRECT REPORTS ON HOW THEY ARE MAKING CHANGES.

Shift Focus to the Future

- Forward Thinking: "Let's look ahead and see how we can move forward."
- Forward Thinking: "What opportunities do you see arising from these changes?"
- Unified Goals: "Together, we can achieve our goals in this new environment."
- Unified Goals: "How can we work together to achieve our goals moving forward?"

Advise and discuss employees' plans for implementing the change.

- Review how your direct reports plan to implement the change using the questions below.
- Have my direct reports overlooked any activities or new behaviors they should be pursuing? Have they identified appropriate success measures that indicate adoption of the new behaviors? At the higher level, do team members share the same objectives and behaviors?
- Are different direct reports learning from each other regarding how they plan to implement the change? Have team members identified the same obstacles to change?
- What can I learn from managers in other parts of the organization as to how their teams are implementing the change?
- How can my team help other teams in making the change?

Have continuous conversations to identify obstacles and support implementation.

- It is hard to predict what change will look like in practice, so support your direct reports throughout implementation.
- Are new projects or initiatives I have assigned supporting or interfering with a direct report's change objectives or priorities?
- Are there any obstacles we did not foresee that I can help overcome, or that I should communicate up?
- Am I keeping my direct reports updated on changing organizational priorities?



5. WRAP-UP/CLOSING

Summarize

- Recap Discussion: Highlight the main challenges and proposed solutions.
- Outline Next Steps: Detail the support resources available and immediate next steps.
- Consider sharing an anonymous survey to gather additional feedback.

Express Appreciation

- Thank Team: "Thank you all for your openness and valuable input today."
- Thank Team: Consider sending a written thank you note to the team.
- Reinforce Communication: Emphasize the importance of ongoing communication and support.

Follow-up

- Schedule Ongoing Conversations: Arrange a follow-up session to review progress and address further concerns.
- Offer Ongoing Support: Ensure a clear plan for continued support and communication.



6. TIPS TO STAY ON TRACK

KEEPING A CONVERSATION GOING IS NOT JUST ABOUT TALKING—IT'S ABOUT **LISTENING**, **UNDERSTANDING**, AND **CONNECTING** ON A DEEPER LEVEL.

01

Reaffirm the Agenda/Key Topics

Regularly refer back to the agenda to remind of the planned topics. This helps anchor the discussion and realign to the intended focus.

02

Use a Parking Lot

A parking lot is a tool that helps you capture and defer any issues or questions that are not relevant or urgent for the current discussion.

03

Implement Time Management

Use a timer/assign time limit to each topic. Gently remind participants when it's time to move on to ensure everyone has an opportunity to share feedback.

04

Keep Additional Topics Handy

Prepare a few potential conversation topics that will interest the participants you're talking to ahead of time. This will help if the conversation lags and you need keep the conversation going.

05

Ask Open-Ended Questions

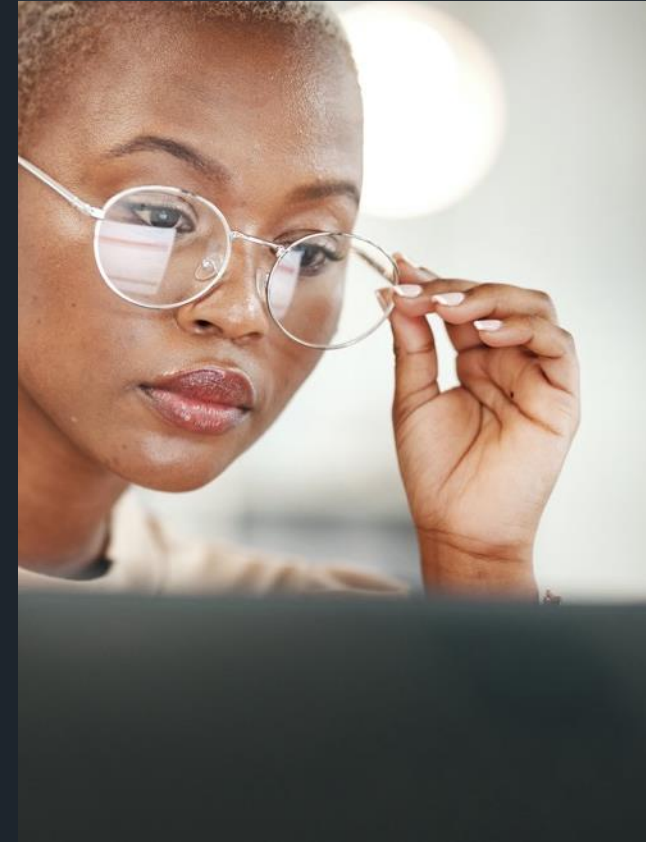
Instead of yes-or-no questions, ask open-ended questions that invite the other person to share more information and expand on their thoughts.



QUESTIONS OR SUPPORT?

 Email Us: HRBP@RealPage.com or contact your assigned HRBP

 **Additional Resources:**
[Change Management – Leaders' Toolkit](#)
[Team Building and Icebreakers](#)





Thank You!

